

» COVER PACKAGE INDIAN GOLD MEDAL PROSPECTS

India heads into the 2026 Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya aiming to build on its record-breaking performance at the 2023 Asian Games. India won 28 gold medals in Hangzhou, and several of those champions return to defend their titles. The Indian contingent will compete across a wide range of disciplines, with shooting, athletics, badminton, wrestling, boxing, weightlifting, hockey and cricket among the sports offering significant gold-medal possibilities.

The biggest talking point, however, has been Neeraj Chopra (**below**). The Olympic champion was initially included in India's athletics squad and was expected to headline the country's gold-medal prospects in the men's javelin, where he was targeting a third successive Asian Games title. However, a ligament injury forced Chopra to end his 2026 season early, and he was subsequently replaced in the squad by Commonwealth Games bronze medallist Yash Vir Singh.

Chopra's absence undoubtedly alters India's medal calculations, but it does not diminish the depth of the challenge. From established champions and Olympic medallists to emerging stars who impressed at the Commonwealth Games, India has several athletes and teams capable of standing atop the podium. Here are the leading gold-medal prospects to watch out for, along with other Indian athletes who could make their mark.

Compiled by Jayantho Sengupta, Jonathan Selvaraj, Nihit Sachdeva, Santadeep Dey, Rajdeep Saha and Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan



ATHLETICS

TOTAL MEDALS AT STAKE
150

Men



Gurindervir Singh (100m); **Animesh Kujur** (100m, 200m); **Rajesh Ramesh and Vishal Thennarasu Kayalvizhi** (400m, 4x400m Relay); **Krishan Kumar and Mohammed Afsal** (800m); **Yoonus Shah** (1500m); **Gulveer Singh** (1500m, 5000m, 10,000m); **Sawan Barwal and Kartik Karkera** (Marathon); **Yashas Palaksha and Santhosh Kumar Tamilarasan** (400m Hurdles); **Avinash Sable** (3000m Steeplechase); **Pranav Pramod Gurav** (4x100m Mixed Relay); **Mohammed Ashfaq, Dharmveer Choudhary, Jay Kumar and Manu Thekkinalil Saji** (4x400m Relays); **Animesh Kujur, Gurindervir Singh, Jay Kumar, Manu Thekkinalil Saji** (Mixed 4x100m Relay); **Aadarsh Ram Jothi Shankar and Sarvesh Kushare** (High Jump); **Kuldeep Kumar and Dev Meena** (Pole Vault); **Murali Sreeshankar and Shahnava Khan** (Long Jump); **Praveen Chithravel and Karthik Unnikrishnan** (Triple Jump); **Karanveer Singh and Tajinderpal Singh Toor** (Shot Put); **Damneet Singh and Praveen Kumar** (Hammer Throw); **Rohit Yadav and Yash Vir Singh** (Javelin Throw); **Thowfeeq Noushad and Tejaswin Shankar** (Decathlon)

Women



Prachi Choudhary and Kiran Pahal (400m); **Gowthami Jayaraman** (800m); **Pooja Olla** (800m, 1500m); **Parul Chaudhary** (1500m, 5000m, 3000m Steeplechase); **Seema** (5000m, 10,000m); **Priyanka Goswami and Manju Rani** (Marathon Race Walk); **Jyothi Yarraji and Nandhini Kongan** (100m Hurdles); **Unnathi Aiyappa Bolland and Harita Bhadra** (200m); **Anu Raghavan and Vithya Ramraj** (400m Hurdles); **Ankita Dhyani** (3000m Steeplechase); **Tamanna, Nithya Gandhe, Srabani Nanda, Abinaya Rajarajan, Sneha Sathyanarayana and Sudeshna Shivankar** (4x100m Relays); **Unnathi Aiyappa Bolland, Tamanna, Sneha Sathyanarayana** (Mixed 4x100m Relays); **Rashdeep Kaur, Ansa Babu, Machettira Raju Poovamma, Kumari Saloni, Neeru Pathak, Kiran Pahal, Vithya Ramraj and Prachi Choudhary** (4x400m Relays); **Rashdeep Kaur, Ansa Babu and Harita Bhadra** (Mixed 4x400m Relays); **Pooja Singh and Supriya Sindigere Basavaraju** (High Jump); **Baranica Elangovan and Sindhushree G** (Pole Vault); **Shaili Singh and Ancy Sojan** (Long Jump); **Niharika Vashisht and I. Asha Ilango** (Triple Jump); **Manpreet Kaur and Krishna Jayasankar Menon** (Shot Put); **Seema Kaliramna and Sanya Yadav** (Discus Throw); **Tanya Chaudhary and Anushka Yadav** (Hammer Throw); **Annu Rani** (Javelin Throw); **Pooja and Anamika Kozhinjaparambil Aneesh** (Heptathlon)